

I-Chip PS 2 Documentation

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1 Mathematical Foundation

AES (Advanced Encryption Standard) is a symmetric-key block cipher that secures data by processing 128-bit blocks. It relies on Galois Field arithmetic to ensure that every mathematical operation is reversible for decryption while remains computationally "scrambled" for security. AES-128 consists of three linear transformations—ShiftRows, MixColumns, and AddRoundKey and one non-linear step, SubBytes. This non-linear step requires calculating a multiplicative inverse in the Galois Field $GF(2^8)$, traditionally implemented using a 256-byte Look-Up Table (S-Box). However, a fully pipelined 10-round hardware architecture would require 160 concurrent copies of this table, creating a massive memory and logic overhead. In this project we do a direct calculation of S-box using sub-field arithmetic as a high-efficiency alternative to memory-heavy tables, the underlying mathematical decomposition into $GF((2^4)^2)$ is more complex to describe, its hardware implementation is remarkably simple, requiring significantly fewer logic gates and zero block memory (BRAM). A Simple Mathematical Description of our S-box implementation is as follows (This is not necessary to understand but still for the sake of it we are documenting this):

AES operates on 8-bit bytes, treated as elements of a Galois Field $GF(2^8)$. The most mathematically demanding part of AES is the SubBytes step, which requires finding the multiplicative inverse of a byte. Doing this directly in $GF(2^8)$ involves solving a 7th-degree polynomial modulo an 8th-degree irreducible polynomial ($q(x) = x^8 + x^4 + x^3 + x + 1$). In hardware, calculating this directly is "expensive" in terms of logic gates. So we break the 8-bit field into smaller, nested subfields. This is known as **Composite Fields** solution. In this instead of looking at a byte as one 8-bit unit, we view it as a linear polynomial over a 4-bit field ($GF(2^4)$).

The representation becomes $G = \gamma_1 y + \gamma_0$ where, γ_1 and γ_0 are just 4-bit nibbles from sub-field ($GF(2^4)$). y acts as the "unit" or "basis element" that elevates these 4-bit values into the 8-bit space ($GF(2^8)$). Now its upto the designer to select the basis (y) in each sub field to get the desired efficiency.

We had two choices:

- (1) **Polynomial Basis** $[y, 1]$: Here, y is any one of the root $r(y)$. Any element is a linear combination of y^1 and y^0 .
- (2) **Normal Basis** $[y^{16}, y]$: Here y and y^{16} both are roots of irreducible polynomial $r(y) = y^2 + \tau y + \nu$.

We can get confused easily if we see y as a continuous value which is not the case we can draw an analogy from complex numbers to understand y as i in $a + bi$ and we know i extends the dimension of real numbers into complex plane so y is a dimensional factor which on combining linearly with $GF(2^4)$ coefficients γ_1 and γ_0 extends the dimension to $GF(2^8)$. Another question which someone can ask is why we are using Galois Field in the first place can't we work with normal arithmetic?

No, we can't because:

- (1) Encryption needs math that is reversible (Inversion/Division).
- (2) Computers need that math to stay within 8 bits (Galois Fields).
- (3) Polynomials provide the "Remainder" trick of Long Division to keep the math within 8 bits.

Well the math isn't conventional but it is certainly beautiful.

To make operations less expensive we do **Tower Field Construction** nesting the fields like a Russian Matryoshka doll: $GF(2^8) \rightarrow GF(2^4) \rightarrow GF(2^2)$

Breaking $GF(2^8)$ into $GF(2^4) \rightarrow GF(2^2)$ allows us to replace a single complex 8-bit inversion with a few simple 4-bit multiplications and a 4-bit inverter. This reduction works because the complexity of Galois math grows quadratically with bit-width, so several small operations are much "cheaper" in logic gates than

one large 8-bit operation.

AES uses irreducible polynomial $q(x) = x^8 + x^4 + x^3 + x + 1$ for modular multiplication. If A is a root of this polynomial, any byte can be expressed as a linear combination of the standard polynomial basis: $[A^7, A^6, A^5, A^4, A^3, A^2, A, 1]$.

To represent an element $G \in GF(2^8)$ in a composite field, we express it as a linear polynomial $G = \gamma_1 y + \gamma_0$ over the 4-bit subfield $GF(2^4)$. This transformation uses the basis $[y, 1]$ and performs multiplication modulo the irreducible polynomial $r(y) = y^2 + \tau y + \nu$, where the coefficients γ_1 and γ_0 are elements of $GF(2^4)$.

Instead of a polynomial basis, we can use the normal basis $[Y^{16}, Y]$ formed by the two roots of $r(y)$. In this representation, the coefficients τ and ν of the irreducible polynomial $r(y) = y^2 + \tau y + \nu$ directly correspond to the trace ($\tau = Y + Y^{16}$) and the norm ($\nu = Y \cdot Y^{16}$) of the root Y .

Following the same logic, we represent each 4-bit element $\gamma \in GF(2^4)$ as a linear polynomial $\gamma = \Gamma_1 z + \Gamma_0$ over the 2-bit subfield $GF(2^2)$. This step uses the basis $[z, 1]$ and performs multiplication modulo the irreducible polynomial $s(z) = z^2 + Tz + N$, where T and N represent the trace and norm of the root Z .

Finally, the 2-bit elements $\Gamma \in GF(2^2)$ are expressed as linear polynomials $\Gamma = g_1 w + g_0$ over the 1-bit field $GF(2)$. In this final stage, the coefficients g_1 and g_0 are single bits, and multiplication is modulo $t(w) = w^2 + w + 1$. This uses the polynomial basis $[W, 1]$ or the normal basis $[W^2, W]$, where both the trace and norm of W are equal to 1.

Across all these subfields, addition and subtraction are equivalent operations implemented as a simple bitwise XOR, regardless of the chosen basis.

In $GF(2^8)$ using a polynomial basis, multiplication modulo $y^2 + \tau y + \nu$ is defined as:

$$(\gamma_1 y + \gamma_0)(\delta_1 y + \delta_0) = (\gamma_1 \delta_0 + \gamma_0 \delta_1 + \gamma_1 \delta_1 \tau)y + (\gamma_0 \delta_0 + \gamma_1 \delta_1 \nu)$$

Proof and Derivation of the $GF(2^8)$ Inverse

To find the inverse of an element $G = \gamma_1 y + \gamma_0$ in $GF(2^8)$, we seek an inverse $G^{-1} = \delta_1 y + \delta_0$ such that:

$$(\gamma_1 y + \gamma_0)(\delta_1 y + \delta_0) = 1 \pmod{y^2 + \tau y + \nu}$$

$$(\gamma_1 \delta_0 + \gamma_0 \delta_1 + \gamma_1 \delta_1 \tau)y + (\gamma_0 \delta_0 + \gamma_1 \delta_1 \nu) = 0y + 1$$

To determine the components of the inverse $G^{-1} = \delta_1 y + \delta_0$ in $GF(2^8)$, we solve the following system of linear equations over the $GF(2^4)$ subfield:

$$\begin{cases} \gamma_1 \delta_0 + (\gamma_0 + \gamma_1 \tau) \delta_1 = 0 \\ \gamma_0 \delta_0 + (\gamma_1 \nu) \delta_1 = 1 \end{cases}$$

Solving for δ_1 and δ_0 yields:

$$\delta_1 = \theta^{-1} \gamma_1, \quad \delta_0 = \theta^{-1} (\gamma_0 + \gamma_1 \tau)$$

where the determinant θ is defined as:

$$\theta = \gamma_1^2 \nu + \gamma_1 \gamma_0 \tau + \gamma_0^2$$

The process of finding an inverse in $GF(2^8)$ is reduced to a single inversion and several multiplications within the $GF(2^4)$ subfield. Similar recursive formulas apply for operations in $GF(2^4)$, further decomposing them into $GF(2^2)$. In the $GF(2^2)$ field, the inversion becomes trivial as the inverse of an element Γ is simply its square ($\Gamma^{-1} = \Gamma^2$), an operation that naturally handles the zero-input case without additional logic.

If a normal basis $[Y^{16}, Y]$ is adopted at each level of the tower, the multiplication and inversion formulas in $GF(2^8)$ are modified to reflect the symmetry of the basis. Using the trace τ and norm ν of the root Y , the multiplication of two elements is defined as:

$$(\gamma_1 Y^{16} + \gamma_0 Y)(\delta_1 Y^{16} + \delta_0 Y) = [\gamma_1 \delta_1 \tau + \theta] Y^{16} + [\gamma_0 \delta_0 \tau + \theta] Y$$

where the intermediate term θ is calculated as:

$$\theta = (\gamma_1 + \gamma_0)(\delta_1 + \delta_0) \nu \tau^{-1}$$

Consequently, the multiplicative inverse is derived as:

$$(\gamma_1 Y^{16} + \gamma_0 Y)^{-1} = [\theta^{-1} \gamma_0] Y^{16} + [\theta^{-1} \gamma_1] Y$$

where the determinant θ for the normal basis is:

$$\theta = \gamma_1 \gamma_0 \tau^2 + (\gamma_1^2 + \gamma_0^2) \nu$$

This normal basis approach often results in even simpler hardware wiring because the inversion formula only requires swapping the coordinates γ_1 and γ_0 before scaling by θ^{-1} .

To optimize the hardware implementation, we simplify these formulas by selecting specific coefficients for the irreducible polynomials $r(y)$ and $s(z)$. The most efficient design choice is to set the trace to unity ($\tau = 1$ and $T = 1$), as this eliminates several multiplication operations in the logic path. While we cannot set both the trace and the norm to unity (and neither can be zero), prioritizing a unity trace yields the greatest reduction in gate count.

1.1 Hierarchical Structure:

Now we show the structure of operation modules this was taken from Canright's S-box paper.

To maintain mathematical clarity, we define the following operators for the subfield $(GF(2^k))$ arithmetic:

$\oplus$: Addition (implemented as bitwise exclusive-OR)

$\otimes$: Multiplication in the subfield

In $GF(2^8)$, the only complex operation required for the S-box is the multiplicative inverse. The architecture for the normal basis inverter is illustrated in Figure 1:

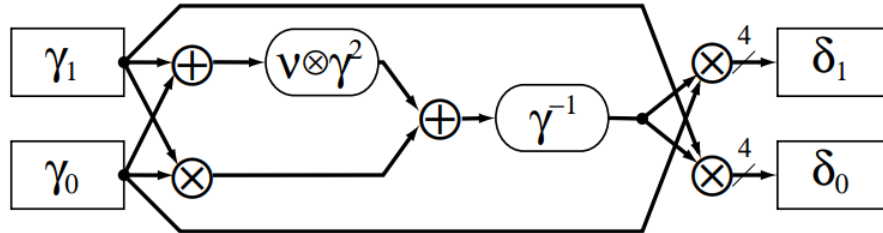


Figure 1: Normal $GF(2^8)$ inverter: $(\gamma_1 Y^{16} + \gamma_0 Y)^{-1} = (\delta_1 Y^{16} + \delta_0 Y)$. The datapaths all have the same bit width (4 bits for this stage); addition is implemented via bitwise exclusive-OR, and sub-field multipliers are utilized. The $GF(2^4)$ inverter follows the same recursive structure, while in $GF(2^2)$, inversion is computationally free, requiring only a bit swap.

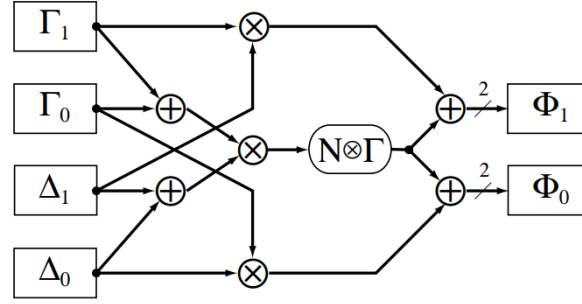


Figure 2: The multiplication in the $GF(2^4)$ subfield is performed using a normal basis $\{Z^4, Z\}$, where the product $(\Phi_1 Z^4 + \Phi_0 Z)$ is derived as follows:
 $(\Gamma_1 Z^4 + \Gamma_0 Z) \otimes (\Delta_1 Z^4 + \Delta_0 Z) = (\Phi_1 Z^4 + \Phi_0 Z)$ The internal logic for the $GF(2^4)$ multiplier is recursively applied to the $GF(2^2)$ level with one key simplification: the $GF(2^2)$ multiplier lacks the scaling factor ν , as the norm in that specific subfield is equal to 1.

2 S-box Implementation in Verilog

2.1 Hardware Implementation of the $GF(2^4)$ Recursive Inverter

```

1  'timescale 1ns / 1ps
2  module gf4_inv (q, a);
3      input    [3:0]    a;
4      output   [3:0]    q;
5      wire     [1:0]    t, t0, t1, t2, q1, q0;
6
7      // Subfield summation
8      assign t = a[3:2] ^ a[1:0];
9
10     // Subfield multiplication
11     gf2_mul m0 (.q(t0), .a(a[3:2]), .b(a[1:0]));
12
13     // Square and scale
14     gf2_sqr_scale s0 (.q(t1), .a(t));
15
16     // Determinant inversion
17     gf2_inv inv0 (.q(t2), .a(t0 ^ t1));
18
19     // Final coordinate scaling
20     gf2_mul m1 (.q(q1), .a(t2), .b(a[1:0]));
21     gf2_mul m2 (.q(q0), .a(t2), .b(a[3:2]));
22
23     // Concatenation
24     assign q = {q1, q0};
25
26 endmodule

```

Listing 1: Verilog implementation of the $GF(2^4)$ Inverter

The module `gf4_inv` implements the multiplicative inverse in the subfield $GF(2^4)$ using a nested Normal Basis $\{Z^4, Z\}$. The 4-bit input a is partitioned into two 2-bit coordinates, γ_1 ($a[3:2]$) and γ_0 ($a[1:0]$), refer to figure 1. The inversion logic follows the recursive decomposition defined by:

$$a^{-1} = (\gamma_1 Z^4 + \gamma_0 Z)^{-1} = \delta_1 Z^4 + \delta_0 Z \quad (1)$$

The internal signals in the Verilog implementation correspond to the following mathematical operations in the $GF(2^2)$ subfield, as illustrated in the architecture diagram:

- **Coordinate Summation (t):** Calculates the subfield addition $(\gamma_1 \oplus \gamma_0)$ via the first $\oplus$ operator.
- **Norm Product (t0):** Computed by `m_0`, representing the subfield multiplication $(\gamma_1 \otimes \gamma_0)$.
- **Square and Scale (t1):** Computed by `s_0`, implementing the block labeled $\nu \otimes \gamma^2$. It represents the term $((\gamma_1 \oplus \gamma_0)^2 \otimes \nu)$.
- **Determinant Inversion (t2):** The determinant $\theta = t_0 \oplus t_1$ is passed through the γ^{-1} block (`inv_0`). In this $GF(2^2)$ normal basis, this inversion is a zero-cost operation.
- **Output Scaling (q1, q0):** The final 2-bit coordinates are generated by the output multipliers:

$$\delta_1 = \gamma^{-1} \otimes \gamma_0 \quad (2)$$

$$\delta_0 = \gamma^{-1} \otimes \gamma_1 \quad (3)$$

The final 4-bit output is concatenated as $\{q1, q0\}$, performing the coordinate swap required to complete the inversion in the composite field.

2.2 Hardware Implementation of the $GF(2^4)$ Normal Basis Multiplier

The module `gf4_mul` computes the product of two 4-bit elements a and b in the composite field $GF(2^4)$ using a nested Normal Basis, refer to figure 2. The multiplication is decomposed into $GF(2^2)$ operations as follows:

- **Direct Products (t0, t1):** Computed by `m_0` and `m_1`, representing the component-wise products $(\Gamma_0 \otimes \Delta_0)$ and $(\Gamma_1 \otimes \Delta_1)$.
- **Sum Product (t2):** Computed by `m_2`, representing the product of the coordinate sums: $(\Gamma_1 \oplus \Gamma_0) \otimes (\Delta_1 \oplus \Delta_0)$.
- **Norm Scaling (t3):** The term t_2 is scaled by the subfield norm $\nu = \omega$ via the `sc1` block.
- **Result Assembly:** The 4-bit output $q = \{\Phi_1, \Phi_0\}$ is reconstructed via subfield addition (XOR):

$$\Phi_1 = (t_2 \otimes \nu) \oplus (\Gamma_1 \otimes \Delta_1) \quad (4)$$

$$\Phi_0 = (t_2 \otimes \nu) \oplus (\Gamma_0 \otimes \Delta_0) \quad (5)$$

The corresponding Verilog implementation is provided below:

```

1  'timescale 1ns / 1ps
2  module gf4_mul (q, a, b);
3      input  [3:0]  a, b;
4      output [3:0]  q;
5      wire  [1:0]  t0, t1, t2, t3;
6
7      gf2_mul m0 (.q(t0), .a(a[1:0]), .b(b[1:0]));
8      gf2_mul m1 (.q(t1), .a(a[3:2]), .b(b[3:2]));
9      gf2_mul m2 (.q(t2), .a(a[3:2] ^ a[1:0]), .b(b[3:2] ^ b[1:0]));
10
11     gf2_scale sc1 (.q(t3), .a(t2));
12
13     assign q = {(t3 ^ t1), (t3 ^ t0)};
14
15 endmodule

```

Listing 2: Verilog implementation of the $GF(2^4)$ Multiplier

2.3 Hardware Implementation of the $GF(2^4)$ Square-and-Scale Block

The module `gf4_sqr_scale` implements the combined squaring and constant scaling operation in $GF(2^4)$. This block is a critical component for calculating the field determinant θ required for the inversion path.

- **Subfield Squaring (t11):** The high 2-bit nibble Γ_1 is squared in the $GF(2^2)$ subfield via the `s0` block.
- **Square and Scale (t10):** The low 2-bit nibble Γ_0 is simultaneously squared and scaled by the norm $\nu = \omega$ via the `s1` block.
- **Linear Reconstruction:** Due to the properties of the Normal Basis, the results are XORed and rearranged to form the final 4-bit output $q = \{\Phi_1, \Phi_0\}$:

$$\Phi_1 = (\Gamma_0^2 \otimes \omega) \oplus \Gamma_1^2 \quad (6)$$

$$\Phi_0 = \Gamma_1^2 \quad (7)$$

The corresponding Verilog implementation is provided below:

```

1  'timescale 1ns / 1ps
2  module gf4_sqr_scale (q, a);
3      input    [3:0]    a;
4      output   [3:0]    q;
5      wire     [1:0]    t10, t11;
6
7      gf2_sqr_scale s0 (.q(t10), .a(a[1:0]));
8      gf2_sqr s1 (.q(t11), .a(a[3:2]));
9
10     assign q = {(t10 ^ t11), t11};
11
12 endmodule

```

Listing 3: Verilog implementation of the $GF(2^4)$ Square-and-Scale Module

2.4 Hardware Implementation of the $GF(2^2)$ Normal Basis Inverter

The module `gf2_inv` implements the multiplicative inverse at the lowest level of the composite field tower. This operation is the most optimized component of the S-Box architecture.

- **Zero-Cost Inversion:** In a $GF(2^2)$ Normal Basis, the multiplicative inverse of an element is identical to its square ($a^{-1} = a^2$).
- **Wire Permutation:** Due to the linear properties of the normal basis, squaring an element results in a simple swap of its coordinate bits.
- **Implementation:** The 2-bit input $a = \{a_1, a_0\}$ is transformed into the output $q = \{a_0, a_1\}$. This is achieved through a direct bit-swap without the use of any active logic gates.

The corresponding Verilog implementation is provided below:

```

1  'timescale 1ns / 1ps
2  module gf2_inv (q, a);
3      input    [1:0]    a;
4      output   [1:0]    q;
5
6      assign q[1] = a[0];
7      assign q[0] = a[1];
8
9  endmodule

```

Listing 4: Verilog implementation of the $GF(2^2)$ Inverter

2.5 Hardware Implementation of the $GF(2^2)$ Normal Basis Multiplier

The module `gf2_mul` performs the base-level multiplication in the $GF(2^2)$ subfield. This architecture utilizes the symmetry of the Normal Basis defined by the polynomial $w^2 + w + 1$.

- **Common Term (t):** Calculates the product of the coordinate sums: $(a_1 \oplus a_0) \cdot (b_1 \oplus b_0)$. This term is shared between both output coordinates.
- **Symmetric Output Logic:** The final coordinates are generated by XORing the common term `t` with the direct bitwise products of the inputs.
- **Resource Efficiency:** The multiplier is implemented using only 3 XOR gates and 3 AND gates, making it highly area-efficient for the recursive S-Box design.

The corresponding Verilog implementation is provided below:

```
1  `timescale 1ns / 1ps
2  module gf2_mul (q, a, b);
3      input  [1:0]  a, b;
4      output [1:0]  q;
5      wire      t;
6
7      assign t = (a[1] ^ a[0]) & (b[1] ^ b[0]);
8
9      assign q[1] = t ^ (a[1] & b[1]);
10     assign q[0] = t ^ (a[0] & b[0]);
11
12 endmodule
```

Listing 5: Verilog implementation of the $GF(2^2)$ Multiplier

2.6 Hardware Implementation of the $GF(2^2)$ Normal Basis ω -Scaler

The module `gf2_scale` performs a constant multiplication by the field norm ω within the $GF(2^2)$ subfield. This linear scaling is a fundamental building block for the higher-level $GF(2^4)$ multipliers and squarers.

- **Field Norm Scaling:** The operation implements $q = a \otimes \omega$, where ω is the constant defining the subfield extension $GF(2^2)/GF(2)$.
- **Linear Transformation:** Because scaling by a constant is a linear operation in Galois Fields, it is reduced to a simple combination of input bits.
- **Logic Minimization:** The implementation requires only one XOR gate. The MSB (`q[1]`) is the sum of the input bits, while the LSB (`q[0]`) is a direct pass-through of the input MSB.

The corresponding Verilog implementation is provided below:

```
1  `timescale 1ns / 1ps
2  module gf2_scale (q, a);
3      input  [1:0]  a;
4      output [1:0]  q;
5
6      assign q[1] = a[1] ^ a[0];
7      assign q[0] = a[1];
8
9  endmodule
```

Listing 6: Verilog implementation of the $GF(2^2)$ Scaler

2.7 Hardware Implementation of the $GF(2^2)$ Normal Basis Squarer

The module `gf2_sqr` performs the squaring operation at the base level of the tower field. Like the $GF(2^2)$ inverter, this module exploits the properties of the Normal Basis to achieve a zero-logic implementation.

- **Frobenius Map:** Squaring in $GF(2^k)$ is a linear operation. In a Normal Basis, the square of an element is simply a cyclic shift of its coordinates.
- **Identity in $GF(2^2)$:** For the two-dimensional case, a cyclic shift is equivalent to a bit-swap ($q_1 = a_0$ and $q_0 = a_1$).
- **Computational Cost:** The operation is "free" in terms of hardware resources, requiring only a physical crossing of wires and no logic gates (XOR/AND).

The corresponding Verilog implementation is provided below:

```

1  `timescale 1ns / 1ps
2  module gf2_sqr (q, a);
3      input    [1:0]    a;
4      output   [1:0]    q;
5
6      assign q[1] = a[0];
7      assign q[0] = a[1];
8
9  endmodule

```

Listing 7: Verilog implementation of the $GF(2^2)$ Squarer

2.8 Hardware Implementation of the $GF(2^2)$ Normal Basis Square-and-Scale Block

The module `gf2_sqr_scale` performs the composite operation of squaring followed by constant multiplication by the norm ω within the base $GF(2^2)$ subfield. This module is a vital component for calculating the 4-bit determinant θ in the recursive inversion path.

- **Combined Arithmetic:** The operation implements $q = a^2 \otimes \omega$. By merging the square and scaling steps, the hardware implementation is optimized into a single linear mapping.
- **Linear Transformation:** The transformation is derived from the properties of the Normal Basis and the irreducible polynomial $\omega^2 + \omega + 1 = 0$.
- **Logic Implementation:** The module is realized with a single XOR gate. The MSB ($q[1]$) is the sum of the input bits, while the LSB ($q[0]$) is a direct pass-through of the input LSB.

The corresponding Verilog implementation is provided below:

```

1  `timescale 1ns / 1ps
2  module gf2_sqr_scale (q, a);
3      input    [1:0]    a;
4      output   [1:0]    q;
5
6      assign q[1] = a[1] ^ a[0];
7      assign q[0] = a[0];
8
9  endmodule

```

Listing 8: Verilog implementation of the $GF(2^2)$ Square-and-Scale Module

3 Architectural Approach



Figure 3: Pipeline Diagram

3.1 Operational Modes and Logic

The architecture is parameterized by a `MODE` signal, which determines how the input data is processed before entering the encryption rounds:

- **ECB Mode (`MODE = 0`):** The 128-bit `message` is directly encrypted using the standard Rijndael algorithm.
- **CTR Mode (`MODE = 1`):** The engine encrypts a block formed by a 96-bit `nonce` concatenated with a 32-bit internal `counter`. The resulting keystream is then XORed with the delayed original message to produce the ciphertext:

$$\text{Ciphertext} = E_K(\text{nonce} \parallel \text{counter}) \oplus \text{Message} \quad (8)$$

3.2 Pipeline Stage Decomposition

The design utilizes a 11-stage pipeline to ensure that a new 128-bit block can be accepted on every clock cycle. Each stage is separated by a `Latch` module, which acts as a synchronization boundary.

1. **Stage 0 (Initialization):** Performs the initial *AddRoundKey* transformation. It also triggers the `KeyEX` module to generate the first round key.
2. **Rounds 1–9 (Intermediate Stages):** Each stage is handled by the `Stage_i` module. These modules execute the four standard AES transformations: *SubBytes*, *ShiftRows*, *MixColumns*, and *AddRoundKey*. Each stage is assigned a unique Round Constant (*Rcon*) for the key schedule.
3. **Round 10 (Final Stage):** Following the FIPS 197 standard, the final round omits the *MixColumns* transformation. It consists only of *SubBytes* (`Sbox`), *ShiftRows* (`Shift_Rows`), and the final *AddRoundKey* (`AddRK`).

3.3 Control and Synchronization

The module manages data flow through several internal control signals:

- **Stall Logic:** The `stall` signal, derived from the `start` input, allows the pipeline to be paused without losing the current state of encryption.
- **Validity Propagation:** A `valid` bit travels through each `Latch` alongside the data. The `valid_out` signal is only asserted when the specific data block has completed all 10 rounds of encryption.
- **Message Delay Path:** In CTR mode, the original plaintext must be XORed with the output of the 10th round. To ensure synchronization, the original `message` is passed through the pipeline via `mess_out` wires, ensuring the plaintext and the encrypted counter arrive at the output XOR gate simultaneously.

3.4 Pipeline Timing and Throughput

After the 11-cycle pipeline fill, a new plaintext block can be accepted on every rising clock edge (when `start = 1`, `valid_in = 1`, `key_valid = 1`). A stall event (`start = 0`) freezes all 11 stages simultaneously — no data is lost or corrupted, and the pipeline resumes from the exact same state once `start` is re-asserted.

Table 1: Performance characteristics of the AES-128 pipelined design

Parameter	ECB Mode	CTR Mode
Pipeline depth	11 stages	11 stages
Fill latency	11 clock cycles	11 clock cycles
Throughput	1 block / cycle	1 block / cycle
Block size	32 bits	32 bits
Key size	128 bits	128 bits
Counter reset	N/A	On start = 0
Output formula	$\text{AES}_k(m)$	$\text{AES}_k(n c) \oplus m$

3.5 Control Unit

The **Controller** module acts as the master data orchestrator for the AES-128 encryption system. It facilitates the communication between a 32-bit external memory interface (AXI-lite) and the 128-bit internal pipelined AES core. Its primary responsibilities include data word assembly, address generation, and synchronization of the encryption pipeline.

3.5.1 Data Width Conversion and Assembly

Since the AES core operates on 128-bit blocks while the memory interface provides 32-bit data (**Rdata**), the controller implements a serialized assembly mechanism:

- **Read Path (32-bit to 128-bit):** A 2-bit counter, **tempcnt**, tracks the arrival of four consecutive 32-bit words. These words are latched into the 128-bit **message** register in a specific order:

$$\text{tempcnt} = 0 \implies \text{message}[127 : 96] \quad (9)$$

$$\text{tempcnt} = 1 \implies \text{message}[95 : 64] \quad (10)$$

$$\text{tempcnt} = 2 \implies \text{message}[63 : 32] \quad (11)$$

$$\text{tempcnt} = 3 \implies \text{message}[31 : 0] \quad (12)$$

Once the fourth word is received (**tempcnt** == 3), the **message_valid** signal is pulsed to trigger the first stage of the AES pipeline.

- **Write Path (128-bit to 32-bit):** Upon receiving the **valid** signal from the AES core, the 128-bit **cipher_text** is stored in a **cipher_accum** register. It is then disassembled into 32-bit chunks using the **tempw_cnt** index to drive the **Wdata** output bus over four cycles.

3.5.2 Memory Interface and Flow Control

The controller implements AXI-Lite handshaking protocol with a 32 bit data path:

- **Address Generation:** The module automatically calculates the read address (**ARaddr**) by adding the **Rcounter** offset to the base **source_address**. This allows the system to fetch the exact number of blocks requested by the user.
- **Handshaking Logic:** The **ARvalid** and **AWvalid** signals are asserted only when the system is in the **start_in** state and the memory (**ARready/AWready**) is prepared to accept or provide data.

3.5.3 State and Status Monitoring

The controller provides real-time feedback on the encryption progress via the **status** and **done** signals:

- **Completion Logic:** The `done` signal is asserted when the `Wcounter` matches the total number of blocks, indicating that all encrypted data has been written back to memory.
- **Status Encoding:** The 2-bit `status` output provides the following system states:
 - 2'b11: Process Complete (`done`).
 - 2'b00: Active Encryption (`start_in` is high).
 - 2'b01: System Idle / Waiting for Start.

No error flag is used as in this design as that scenario never arises. By managing the `nonce`, `key`, and `start` signals, the controller serves as a protective wrapper for the AES core. It ensures that the high-speed pipeline is fed with synchronized 128-bit blocks, regardless of the latency or width of the external system bus, maximizing the total cryptographic throughput.

3.6 Memory Implementation

The system utilizes two dedicated memory modules, `Rmem` and `Wmem`, to handle data buffering for the AES engine.

- **Source Memory (`Rmem`):** A synchronous memory that serves as the input buffer. It stores the plaintext data to be encrypted. The read path is triggered by the `ARvalid` signal, which latches the data into `Rdata` on the rising edge of the clock.
- **Destination Memory (`Wmem`):** It is used to store the resulting ciphertext. To improve timing margins during the block-to-word disassembly phase, the `Wmem` write operation is executed on the **falling edge** (`negedge`) of the clock.

3.7 Intermediate Modules

3.7.1 Mix Columns

The `MixColumns` module is implemented as a purely combinational logic block, achieving high efficiency by replacing generic Galois Field multiplication with optimized xor and shift operations. By utilizing a single-bit left shift and a conditional XOR with the AES irreducible polynomial, the module avoids the resource overhead of full multipliers, resulting in a low-latency architecture with a minimal gate count. The module operates on the 128-bit state by treating each 4-byte column as a polynomial in $GF(2^8)[x]$.

- **Galois Field Multiplication (`mult2`):** It performs multiplication by the polynomial x (hex value 0x02) in $GF(2^8)$.

$$\text{mult2}(x) = \begin{cases} (x \ll 1) & \text{if } x[7] = 0 \\ (x \ll 1) \oplus 8'h1B & \text{if } x[7] = 1 \end{cases} \quad (13)$$

The constant 8'h1B represents the irreducible polynomial $x^8 + x^4 + x^3 + x + 1$.

- **Composite Multiplication (`mult3`):** Multiplication by $x + 1$ (hex 0x03) is achieved using the distributive property of the field:

$$\text{mult3}(x) = (02 \otimes x) \oplus (01 \otimes x) = \text{mult2}(x) \oplus x \quad (14)$$

- **Linear Combination:** Each output byte o_i is a linear combination of the input bytes s_i from the same column. For instance, the first output byte is calculated as:

$$o_0 = (02 \otimes s_0) \oplus (03 \otimes s_1) \oplus s_2 \oplus s_3 \quad (15)$$

$$\begin{bmatrix} o_{i,0} \\ o_{i,1} \\ o_{i,2} \\ o_{i,3} \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} 02 & 03 & 01 & 01 \\ 01 & 02 & 03 & 01 \\ 01 & 01 & 02 & 03 \\ 03 & 01 & 01 & 02 \end{bmatrix} \bullet \begin{bmatrix} s_{i,0} \\ s_{i,1} \\ s_{i,2} \\ s_{i,3} \end{bmatrix} \quad (16)$$

Since the fixed matrix contains only 1, 2 and 3 we have implemented this module using only XOR and shift operators.

3.7.2 Shift Rows

The **Shift Rows** module represents a zero-cost hardware operation, as the cyclic row shifts are implemented entirely through static wire permutation. This results in a transformation that consumes no logic gates and introduces zero gate delay within the encryption pipeline.

3.8 Key Schedule Strategy

The architecture utilizes a distributed, *on-the-fly* key expansion strategy specifically optimized for a 10-stage pipelined execution. Instead of pre-calculating a full key schedule and storing it in a central memory, this design integrates the key generation logic directly into the hardware stages of the data path.

3.8.1 Pipelined Key Expansion

The expansion of the 128-bit master key into its constituent round keys is performed concurrently with the data encryption. This "just-in-time" generation is achieved through several structural design choices:

- **Stage-Specific Key Generation:** Each **Stage_i** instance contains its own key expansion logic (**KeyEX** or equivalent sub-module). This allows the $(i + 1)$ -th round key to be derived from the i -th round key within the same clock cycle that the i -th data transformation occurs.
- **Distributed Round Constants (*Rcon*):** To avoid complex control logic, each stage is parameterized with its own unique *Rcon* constant (ranging from `8'h02` to `8'h36`). This hard-wired approach ensures that the non-linear *RotWord* and *SubWord* operations within the key schedule are executed deterministically at each pipeline level.

3.8.2 Synchronous Key Propagation

A critical requirement of a pipelined AES engine is ensuring that the correct round key reaches the *AdRoundKey* logic at the exact moment the corresponding data block arrives.

- **Parallel Latches:** The design uses the **Latch** module to store both the 128-bit state matrix (**text_in**) and the 128-bit round key (**key_in**). By passing the key through the same set of registers as the message, the key schedule is effectively "flowing" through the pipeline at the same rate as the data.
- **Zero Latency Overhead:** Because the key expansion is computed in the combinational logic of each stage, there is no separate "key setup" time. The first block of plaintext can be accepted as soon as the **key_valid** signal is asserted.

3.9 Architectural Benefits

The design demonstrates exceptional *Key Agility*, allowing the master key (**key_in**) to be modified even while the 10-stage pipeline is actively processing data.

- **Causal Key Propagation:** By latching the expanded key alongside the data block at every stage, the architecture ensures that each block of ciphertext is encrypted using the specific key that was present at the input when that block entered the pipeline.

- **Zero-Overhead Re-Keying:** Unlike iterative architectures that require a "key setup" delay or a pipeline flush to update the internal round keys, this design allows for a new master key to be applied on every clock cycle. This causal propagation ensures that the n -th block is encrypted with Key A while the $(n + 1)$ -th block is simultaneously encrypted with Key B, without any cross-contamination or synchronization errors.

4 System Interface and Buffering Design

The AES128 system employs a sophisticated interface and buffering architecture designed to reconcile the mismatch between the 128-bit internal data path and the 32-bit external memory bus. This is achieved through a decoupled synchronization model and a specialized controller-driven buffering scheme.

4.1 Decoupled Memory Buffering

The architecture utilizes two distinct memory entities, **Rmem** (Read Memory) and **Wmem** (Write Memory), which act as asynchronous boundaries for the encryption engine.

- **Source Buffering (Rmem):** A 2048-word buffer that stores raw plaintext. This allows the system to pre-load large datasets, ensuring that the encryption pipeline is never starved of data during high-speed bursts.
- **Result Buffering (Wmem):** A 400-word buffer for encrypted ciphertext. By using a **negedge** clock trigger for write operations, the design increases the setup time available for the final stage of the pipeline, enhancing timing closure at high frequencies.

4.2 Data Width Conversion and Serialization

To interface the 128-bit AES core with 32-bit memories, the **Controller** implements an automated serialization/deserialization logic:

- **Input Assembly:** A 4-to-1 word assembler captures four consecutive 32-bit memory reads to form a single 128-bit "State" block. The **message_valid** signal is only asserted once the full 128-bit vector is latched, preventing the pipeline from processing incomplete data.
- **Output Disassembly:** The 128-bit **cipher_text** is stored in an intermediate **cipher_accum** register and sequentially driven onto the 32-bit **Wdata** bus over four clock cycles, managed by the **tempw_cnt** state machine.

4.3 Status Monitoring

A dedicated 2-bit **status** signal provides external logic with real-time visibility into the buffer state. This allows a host processor to determine if the system is **Idle**, **Processing**, or if the buffers have been successfully flushed upon completion (**done**).

5 Design Performance and Resource Trade-off Analysis

An analysis of the implementation results on the target FPGA platform reveals a highly optimized architecture that successfully balances high-throughput requirements with a minimized area footprint.

6 Resource Efficiency through Composite Field Arithmetic

The utilization report indicates a total consumption of **14,545 Slice LUTs** and **2,204 Slice Registers**. The primary driver for this area efficiency is the implementation of the S-Box using composite field $GF(((2^2)^2)^2)$ arithmetic rather than traditional Look-Up Tables (ROMs).

- **Area Optimization:** By decomposing the $GF(2^8)$ inversion into nested subfield operations, the logic depth is minimized, allowing the AES128 core to occupy only 4.8% of the available Slice LUTs on a typical high-density target.
- **Control Path Leanliness:** The **Controller** module consumes an negligible **37 LUTs**, demonstrating that the data width conversion and AXI-style handshaking logic are implemented with peak architectural efficiency.

6.1 Timing and Throughput Analysis at 125 MHz

The implementation results for a target clock period of **8 ns** demonstrate the high-speed capability of the pipelined architecture. With a Worst Negative Slack (WNS) of **1.576 ns**, the design comfortably meets all setup requirements for a **125 MHz** operational frequency.

- **Maximum Frequency Capability:** The effective critical path delay of the design is 6.424 ns. This provides a theoretical maximum frequency of **155.6 MHz**, offering a 19.7% timing margin (slack) over the 125 MHz target.
- **Throughput Calculation:** Since the 11-stage pipeline produces one 128-bit ciphertext block per clock cycle after the initial latency, the throughput at 125 MHz is calculated as:

$$\text{Throughput} = 128 \text{ bits} \times 125 \text{ MHz} = 16 \text{ Gbps} \quad (17)$$

At the maximum achievable frequency (155 MHz), the throughput scales to approximately **19.8 Gbps**.

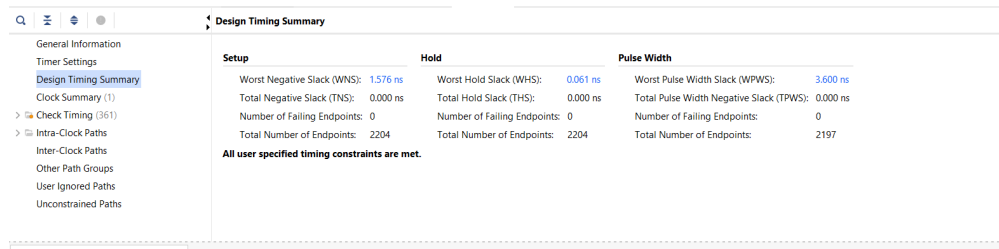
- **Timing Integrity:** The **0.000 ns Total Negative Slack (TNS)** across 2,204 endpoints confirms that the recursive composite field S-Box and the pipelined key expansion logic are perfectly balanced. No single stage creates a bottleneck, ensuring uniform heat distribution and signal integrity across the FPGA fabric.

6.2 Performance-to-Area Trade-off Conclusion

By achieving a 16 Gbps throughput using only 14,545 LUTs, the design reaches an exceptional efficiency of over **1.1 Mbps per LUT**. This confirms that the decision to use a fully pipelined structure combined with gate-level subfield arithmetic provides a superior architectural solution for high-bandwidth cryptographic applications compared to iterative or BRAM-based designs.

7 Conclusion on Design Trade-offs

The chosen architecture prioritizes *throughput-per-area*. While the 11-stage pipeline introduces a 11-cycle initial latency, it allows for the processing of a new 128-bit block every clock cycle. Combined with the gate-level optimization of the S-Box, this design offers a superior performance-to-cost ratio compared to iterative or ROM-based AES implementations.



Design Timing Summary			
General Information	Setup	Hold	Pulse Width
Timer Settings	Worst Negative Slack (WNS): 1.576 ns	Worst Hold Slack (WHS): 0.061 ns	Worst Pulse Width Slack (WPWS): 3.600 ns
Design Timing Summary	Total Negative Slack (TNS): 0.000 ns	Total Hold Slack (THS): 0.000 ns	Total Pulse Width Negative Slack (TPWS): 0.000 ns
Clock Summary (1)	Number of Failing Endpoints: 0	Number of Failing Endpoints: 0	Number of Failing Endpoints: 0
> Check Timing (361)	Total Number of Endpoints: 2204	Total Number of Endpoints: 2204	Total Number of Endpoints: 2197
> Intra-Clock Paths	All user specified timing constraints are met.		
Inter-Clock Paths			
Other Path Groups			
User Ignored Paths			
Unconstrained Paths			

Figure 4: Timing Summary

Name	Slice LUTs (303600)	Block RAM Tile (1030)	Bonded IOB (600)	BUFGCTRL (32)	Slice Registers (607200)	F7 Muxes (151800)	F8 Muxes (75900)	Slice (75900)	LUT as Logic (303600)
Top	14545	1	155	1	2204	5	2	3934	14545
controller (Controller)	37	0	0	0		0	0	51	37
> Encrypt (AES128)	14507	0	0	0		5	2	3911	14507

Figure 5: Resource Usage per module

8 Functional Verification and Robustness Analysis

To ensure the architectural integrity and cryptographic accuracy of the pipelined engine, a rigorous verification suite was executed. The design was subjected to extensive functional testing under both static and dynamic operational conditions.

8.1 Standardized Vector Validation

The core was verified using over **400 industry-standard AES test vectors**, including Known Answer Tests (KAT) for both ECB and CTR modes.

- **Cryptographic Accuracy:** The 128-bit ciphertext outputs were bit-matched against reference software implementations, confirming the functional correctness of the composite field $GF(((2^2)^2)^2)$ S-Box and the MixColumns linear transformations.
- **Corner-Case Coverage:** The test suite included identity keys, all-zero/all-one blocks, and randomized payloads to ensure no data-dependent leakage or logic errors exist in the subfield arithmetic units.

8.2 Dynamic Pipeline Stress Testing

Beyond static verification, the design was tested for robustness during active execution cycles:

- **On-the-Fly Key Variation:** The system successfully demonstrated the ability to vary the master `key_in` during active pipeline execution. Due to the *parallel propagation* of round keys alongside data blocks, the engine correctly encrypted adjacent blocks with different keys without requiring a pipeline flush or reset.
- **Asynchronous Stall and Recovery:** The `stall` mechanism was verified by toggling the `start` signal during active encryption cycles. The 11-stage pipeline correctly preserved all intermediate state and key values, resuming operation with zero data corruption upon restart.
- **Handshaking Integrity:** The Controller’s ability to manage back-pressure was verified by simulating slow memory responses (`Rvalid` and `Wready` de-assertion), confirming that the internal synchronization logic maintains perfect data alignment between the 32-bit memory interface and the 128-bit core.

8.3 Verification Conclusion

The successful completion of these tests confirms that the design is not only high-performance but also computationally robust. The architecture provides a stable, reliable platform for real-time cryptographic applications where system-level interrupts and dynamic key scheduling are frequent requirements.